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Pro Forma Budget Project – Sacramento River Cats

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Pro Forma Budget: AAA Sacramento River Cats 2026 MiLB season

Sacramento River Cats Fast Facts:

1. Affiliation: AAA team for the **San Francisco Giants**
2. 2025 Record: **77-73**; 3rd in the PCL's West Division
3. Stadium: *Sutter Health Park*, Sacramento, California
   - Formerly known as *Raley Field*
4. 2025 Attendance: total of 302,973 people…
   - Averaged **4,040** in **75 home dates**

Why the Sacramento River Cats?

- The River Cats are in a unique situation…in their first year of sharing Sutter Health Field with a Major League Baseball team, the Athletics, the River Cats saw a sharp decline in attendance in their 2025 season…
  - River Cats went from **409,700 (2024) → 302,973 (2025)**
    - **Decreased by 106,727 tickets over ONE SEASON!**
  - Major consumer fan question: "Why go to a Sacramento River Cats Minor League game when I can go to an Athletics Major League game?"
- Our goal is to financially break down this interesting time with the Sacramento River Cats as they continue into the 2026 season, sharing their ballpark…

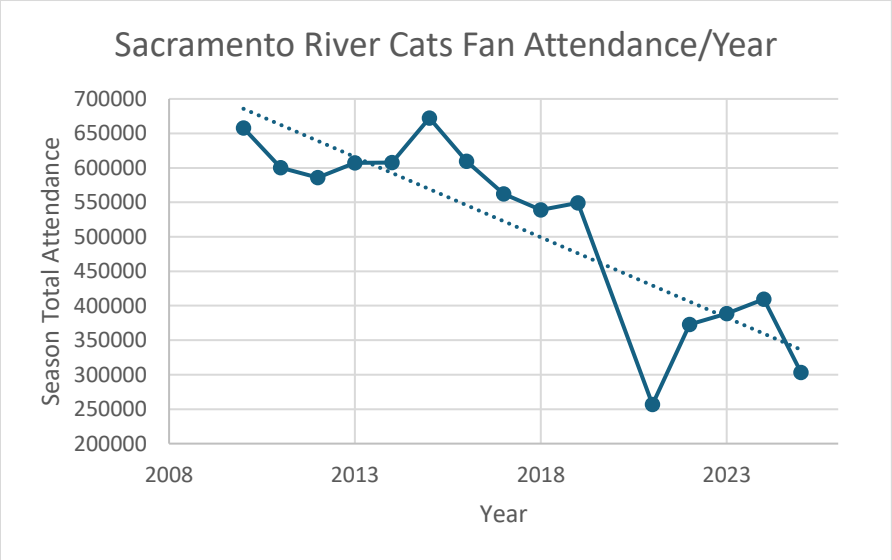
By making reasonable assumptions and estimating their revenue, expenses, and creating a financial statement, we will be able to conclude if the Sacramento River Cats will operate at a profit or a loss for the 2026 season.

Assumptions & Justifications:

Projected 2026 Season Attendance

With the dramatic decrease in overall attendance by an aggregate total of 106,727 tickets, it is safe to assume that the Athletics timeshare will still affect the River Cat ticket sales. Therefore, our projection should place more emphasis on the 2025 season rather than previous years.

In contrast, we are still projecting a slight increase in ticket sales from the 2025 season due to newfound fan familiarity heading into year two of the MLB/MiLB combination.



Therefore, with our linear regression model, we are projecting a slight increase in attendance that still corresponds to the trend of ticket sales since 2010. We can confidently predict that the total attendance in 2026 for the Sacramento River Cats will be around **338,394** tickets! (Attendance Spreadsheet)

Projected Ticket Prices

For a good representation of the "average game," we have decided that a medium-demand game would be most suitable for the Sacramento River Cats vs. Reno Aces on Thursday, May 7th, 2026. We will be using this game for the basis of our projected ticket prices…

Rationale for Selecting this Game:

- The Reno Aces are a rival of the Sacramento River Cats
    - It will be a high-quality game (competition-wise)
- Will be played on a Thursday night during the school calendar year
    - Low to medium attendance for families with children

Overall: This game meets in the middle of the most popular weekend late-July night games and early-season weekday games against less-popular teams.

Ticketmaster's average price per ticket for this game is **$20.77.**

Projected Sponsorship Values

As far as estimating revenue from their sponsorship values, we are assuming that the River Cats have one naming rights partner, five premium partners, and ten regional partners (based on the outfield wall padding). We also counted that they have fifteen upcoming promotional nights with sponsors paying extra. Although it is difficult to project a concrete number of digital advertisements for the stadium, from firsthand visiting of the stadium, we are assuming there are roughly fifty concourse and scoreboard advertising partnerships.

We are justifying that the price fix for individual sponsorship types is as follows:

- Naming Rights Partner: $800,000
- Premium Partnerships: $200,000
- Regional Partnerships: $80,000
- Event & Promotional Nights: $30,000
- Concourse & Digital Advertisements: $6,000

Accounting for these sponsorship categories, we can assume a total of roughly 3.35 million.

2026 Revenue Projections:

Historically, the Sacramento River Cats and Sutter Health Park's revenue is roughly $20 Million per year, which is consistently in the top 25 in MiLB. Based on the projected 2026 attendance of 338,394 and an average ticket price of $20.77, we can estimate the team's ticket sales and primary income categories. Ticket sales, Merchandise, and Concessions remain the largest portion of revenue at an estimated 50% of the team's revenue:

- Ticket Revenue: 20.77 avg ticket price * 338,394 proj. attendance = ~$7,028,443.38
- Concessions and Merchandise (~$3.35 million)
- Sutter Health Naming Rights: ~$800,000 per year (Based on previous deal)
- Sponsorships (~$2 million)
- Parking (~$3 million)
- Media Rights (Undisclosed)
- Sutter Health Park Revenue (Undisclosed)

Ticket Sales

To calculate the revenue from ticket sales, we took the average ticket price on Ticketmaster and multiplied it by the projected attendance. While this is the best estimate we can get, the actual number may vary. Those ticket prices are solely based on a projection from the average game last year, which can change based on many factors (team success, weather, local events, etc.). Also, we aren't accounting for season ticket sales because they vary significantly.

Concessions and Merchandise

For this estimate, we calculated it based on ticketing, concessions, and merchandise, accounting for 50% of the team's revenue. Other than menu prices, we also know that Minor League Baseball and its 160 clubs in the U.S. and Canada combined for a record $85.7 million in licensed merchandise sales in 2019. This accounts for $535,000 per year for each club; however, the River Cats are in the top 25, so they are likely to profit significantly more. We also know that minor league teams hold an average of $1 million in merchandise inventory and incur a 55% cost per good sold.

Sutter Health Naming Rights

While there is no public figure for this naming rights deal, it is likely similar in price to the previous ($750,000 per year). The Oakland Athletics move to the park likely did not affect the price, as the deal was agreed upon before the move.

Sponsorships

There are no public numbers on specific sponsorship costs, but we can estimate that the smaller arena activations cost likely $1,000-2,500. The larger sponsors that are on their website, 40+ corporate brands, likely pay more for the signage and benefits they receive.

Parking

Parking is a major part of the River Cat's revenue as they charge roughly $30 for a parking pass. Assuming there are 1/3 of the number of cars parked as there are people, and using the $30 per parking pass, they are likely generating upwards of $3 million in parking revenue.

Media Rights and Miscellaneous

Both Media Rights and the events at Sutter Health Park draw in a considerable chunk of revenue for the River Cats. Unfortunately, the Media rights deal with CBS is undisclosed. The revenue for the park largely comes from the Athletics rental and other events, but all that information is private.

However, we can project in-park revenue from bingo, raffling, kid-zones, and premium experiences to be above average for the typical minor league baseball team. This is because the Sutter Health field is a great place for families, thanks to its right-field lawn area that lets kids play and parents participate in on-site activities. Therefore, we are projecting an extra $100,000 in revenue over the course of the season from this.

2026 Expense Projections:

Player Payroll

We are projecting that the player payroll is competitive to the top of the AAA range of 2.5 million through 4 million…therefore, we are estimating $3,200,000 payroll.

Front Office Salaries

The front office positions include executives, sales, marketing, and operations. Based on 40 employees, we are estimating front office salaries totaling 2 million dollars.

Stadium Lease / Maintenance

The normal stadium maintenance, such as cleaning services, field upkeep, and security operations are typically high, but some reports claim the Athletics help fund some of these categories. Therefore, we will estimate the lower end of maintenance expenses at 2.5 million dollars.

Marketing

The city of Sacramento is catered to around the Kings and the River Cats. With the brand being well-pushed since 2000, we project the lower end, around 800,000 dollars, for marketing.

Travel Expenses

Moving the team and traveling faculty to road games comes at a price, and with average airplane tickets being roughly 200 dollars round-trip with mass travel, we are estimating that a typical season will bring 6,000 total flights for the team, resulting in an extra 1.2 million dollars in expenses.

Insurance

With general liability insurance, property insurance for the stadium and equipment, and event-day protection coverage, we are budgeting 400,000 dollars annually for insurance.

Utilities

Stadium electricity, water for field irrigation and facilities, natural gas, and waste management services are used twice as much throughout the year with the shared stadium. Therefore, we project a safe 700,000-dollar budget for utilities.

Administrative Expenses

Expenses, including office supplies, legal and accounting services, subscription services, and other miscellaneous operational costs, can be safely budgeted at around 600,000 dollars annually.

Total Operating Expenses

With all of this in mind, we estimate the Sacramento River Cats' total operating costs at 11.4 million dollars.

Sacramento River Cats 2026 Pro Forma Financial Statement:

For Month Ending 12/31/26	
Sales Revenue	
Ticket Sales	$7,028,443.38
Concessions and Merchandise	$3,350,000
Parking	$3,000,000
Sponsorships	$2,000,000
Naming Rights	$800,000
Miscellaneous Game-Day Revenue	$100,000
Total Revenue	**$16,278,443.38**
Cost of Goods Sold	
Concessions Inventory	$1,250,000
Merchandise Inventory	$1,000,000
Game-Day Staffing	$1,000,000
Gross Margin	**$13,028,443.38**
Percent	80%
Operating Expenses	
Player Payroll	$3,200,000
Front Office Salaries	$2,000,000
Stadium Lease/Maintenance	$2,500,000
Marketing	$800,000
Travel Expenses	$1,200,000
Insurance	$400,000
Utilities	$700,000
Administrative Expenses	$600,000
Total Operating Expenses	**$11,400,000**
Net Profit (Loss)	**$1,628,443.38 Profit**

Conclusion: The River Cats Will be Profitable!

In conclusion, with the Sacramento River Cats entering the 2026 MiLB season, we are projecting a profit of **$1,628,443.38**. With this large margin, we are confident that the organization will at

least operate at a profit. This is a testament to the large fanbase the River Cats have maintained over the years, even with a dramatic decrease in ticket sales since hosting the Athletics.

Even further, we can project that the River Cats will profit more than $25,000 per home game. This is a fair number that eliminates travel expenses throughout the year for away games from the overall total.

With their large favor given to the Athletics, it is even reasonable to assume that the organization would profit even more than projected. Especially considering that the Athletics have a global brand, which is big enough to support a Minor League Baseball team on its ticket sales alone.

All in all, our projections are sufficient evidence to claim that the River Cats are financially stable for their upcoming season.

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